tutions, the Birla Institute of Technology & Science (BITS) Pilani is a regular presence in the Ivy League of Indian colleges. With a unique zero-attendance policy, it allows students to choose their classes and instructors. If different teachers are offering the same course, students decide which teacher they prefer, putting the onus on the faculty to attract students to their classes. Students can even tailor their courses by choosing minors, enabling them to take up to 50 per cent of their courses from disciplines outside their core field. In addition to paid internships, they have the option to undertake a research project with the faculty or work on their own startup. Last year, thus, 3,500 students took home Rs 120 crore in stipends.

Innovation in pedagogy is again what has enabled the Tata Institute of Social Sciences to consistently retain the top honours in Social Work. Teaching here is done not just via books but also through films and documentaries to better understand ideas like social justice, and attending national conferences.

All Things Considered

While making a career decision, aspiring students certainly consider the overall excellence of a college. However, equally important for them is the performance of the department teaching the subject that they may wish to take up. It is not necessary that the best college in a stream has the best department in a specific subject. Likewise, the college that has the best department in that subject may not be the best in that stream.

To make the selection easier for students, we introduced a new category last year—best colleges in individual subjects. This exercise has been conducted for 12 subjects in two streams, Arts and Science—Economics, History, English, Psychology, Sociology, Political Science, Physics, Chemistry, Botany, Zoology, Hindi and Sanskrit. The evaluation has been based on the objective data submitted by the colleges.

Students can have a more granular view of how the college of their choice fares as the India Today Best Colleges Survey measures the performance of the colleges across five parameters—'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership

EMERGING DESTINATIONS

STREAM	WINNER	NO. OF COLLEGES
ARTS	PATNA	1
SCIENCE	KOCHI	1
COMMERCE	CHANDIGARH	1
MEDICAL	VARANASI	1
DENTAL SCIENCES	MANGALURU	2
ENGINEERING	KANPUR	2
ARCHITECTURE	LUCKNOW	3
LAW	PUNE	2
MASS COMMUNICATION	BHOPAL	2
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	PUNE	3
BBA	PUNE	1
BCA	PUNE	2
SOCIAL WORK	COIMBATORE	3
FASHION DESIGN	KOLKATA	2

26%
Students enrolled in STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) courses

34%
Undergraduate students enrolled in Arts, 15 per cent in Science, 13 per cent in Commerce and 12 per cent in Engineering & Technology